road access to Leh. Despite occupying the heights overlooking the airfield, the Chinese couldn’t take down Chushul. Having achieved their strategic objectives, the Chinese declared a unilateral ceasefire on 20 November 1962.

India had been served a crushing psychological defeat from which it still has to recover. The military defeat put into perspective Nehru’s delusionary and patronising policy towards China. He simultaneously feared and belittled China through crafty moves which only irritated Mao and forced him to strip Nehru of his international prestige and self-respect. Patel’s caution about China was peremptorily disregarded and the opportunity to check China’s rise and pre-empt the emerging Sino-Pak alliance was lost. Krishna Menon’s disastrous choice of Gen. P. N. Thapar as Indian Army Chief over Gen. Thimayya's choice of Lt. Gen. Thorat provided Nehru with a convenient scapegoat. Gen. Thapar, who was related to the Nehru family by marriage, was told by Nehru to be the fall guy of this disaster. Thapar’s good-natured personality was unequipped to argue down the Krishna Menon-Nehru duo that shrouded itself with the cloak of superciliousness every time Thapar trudged into the South Block or the Teenmurti House, with forebodings of the Chinese threat. When asked to take the rap for the disaster, Gen. Thapar with the humility of a feudal servant, took off his Sam Browne belt and placed it on Nehru’s table. This was the final humiliation that Nehru heaped upon the glorious track record of the Indian Army that had not only empowered the Allies to win two successive victories in both the world wars during the 20th century but also enabled the British Empire to sustain itself over its many, far-flung colonies.

Jammu and Kashmir now had two institutionalised interlopers in its territory. On its northern and western ends, Pakistan had established its powers and on its north-eastern ends, China established itself in strategic niches. The stage was now set to trap India into a pincer and make it bleed with a thousand cuts. This strategy was not the brainchild of either Zulfikar Ali Bhutto or Gen. Zia-ul-Haq but had its origins in the tenure of Lt. Gen. W. J. Cawthorn, who was the longest-serving ISI Chief from 1950–59. For